

VIVIDMED

---

## 5-DAY CHALLENGE

# 50 Essential Medical Terms

---

Pronunciation | Etymology | Mnemonics | Clinical Context

**Day 1** Cardiovascular System

**Day 2** Respiratory System

**Day 3** Digestive System

**Day 4** Nervous System

**Day 5** Musculoskeletal System

# Table of Contents

50 terms across 5 body systems

---

## Day 1: Cardiovascular System

1. Tachycardia
2. Bradycardia
3. Atherosclerosis
4. Hypertension
5. Aneurysm
6. Thrombosis
7. Stenosis
8. Ischemia
9. Cardiomyopathy
10. Endocarditis

## Day 2: Respiratory System

11. Pneumothorax
12. Bronchitis
13. Emphysema
14. Dyspnea
15. Hemoptysis
16. Atelectasis
17. Pleurisy
18. Cyanosis
19. Pulmonary Embolism
20. Asthma

## Day 3: Digestive System

21. Dysphagia
22. Hepatomegaly
23. Cholecystitis
24. Peritonitis
25. Cirrhosis
26. Gastroesophageal Reflux
27. Pancreatitis
28. Diverticulitis
29. Hematemesis
30. Colonoscopy

## Day 4: Nervous System

31. Neuropathy
32. Encephalitis
33. Meningitis
34. Hemiplegia
35. Epilepsy
36. Neuralgia
37. Cerebrovascular Accident
38. Hydrocephalus
39. Paresthesia
40. Sclerosis

## Day 5: Musculoskeletal System

41. Osteoporosis
42. Arthritis
43. Scoliosis
44. Tendinitis
45. Myalgia
46. Fracture
47. Lordosis
48. Bursitis
49. Osteomyelitis
50. Kyphosis

## DAY 1

# Cardiovascular System

The Heart & Blood Vessels

The cardiovascular system is the body's transport network. Mastering these terms will help you understand cardiac pathology, hemodynamics, and vascular disease.

TERM 1 OF 50

## Tachycardia

TAK-in-KAR-dee-un

### DEFINITION

An abnormally rapid heart rate, typically defined as a resting heart rate exceeding 100 beats per minute in adults.

### ETYMOLOGY

tachy- (Greek: fast) + kardia (Greek: heart)

### MEMORY TRICK

*A TAXI (tachy) speeding through the city -- your heart is racing just like that cab!*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A patient presents to the ER with palpitations and HR of 150 bpm. ECG shows supraventricular tachycardia (SVT); the physician attempts a vagal maneuver before considering adenosine.

TERM 2 OF 50

## Bradycardia

BRAD-in-KAR-dee-un

### DEFINITION

An abnormally slow heart rate, typically below 60 beats per minute at rest, which may or may not produce symptoms depending on the patient.

### ETYMOLOGY

brady- (Greek: slow) + kardia (Greek: heart)

### MEMORY TRICK

*Your friend BRADY always moves slowly and is never in a hurry -- that's a brady-heart!*

### CLINICAL USAGE

An elderly patient on a beta-blocker presents with dizziness and fatigue. Telemetry reveals HR of 42 bpm, prompting evaluation for pacemaker implantation.

# Atherosclerosis

ATH-er-oh-skleh-ROH-sis

## DEFINITION

A chronic disease characterized by the buildup of fatty plaques (atheromas) within arterial walls, leading to narrowing and hardening of the vessels.

## ETYMOLOGY

athero- (Greek: gruel/paste) + sclerosis (Greek: hardening)

## MEMORY TRICK

*Smearing thick OATMEAL GRUEL (athero) inside a pipe until it HARDENS (sclerosis) and clogs.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 62-year-old smoker with hyperlipidemia undergoes coronary angiography revealing 85% stenosis of the LAD artery due to atherosclerotic plaque, requiring stent placement.

# Hypertension

HY-per-TEN-shun

## DEFINITION

Persistently elevated arterial blood pressure, defined as systolic  $\geq 130$  mmHg or diastolic  $\geq 80$  mmHg. A major risk factor for stroke, heart failure, and kidney disease.

## ETYMOLOGY

hyper- (Greek: above/excessive) + tension (Latin: stretching/pressure)

## MEMORY TRICK

*A HYPER child bouncing off the walls creates excessive TENSION -- just like blood pushing too hard against artery walls.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 48-year-old patient has consistent readings of 152/96 mmHg at three visits. The physician initiates lisinopril and counsels on dietary sodium reduction.

# Aneurysm

AN-yoo-riz-um

## DEFINITION

An abnormal, localized dilation or ballooning of a blood vessel wall, most commonly in the aorta or cerebral arteries, with risk of rupture.

## ETYMOLOGY

aneurysma (Greek: a widening, from ana- 'up' + eurys 'wide')

## MEMORY TRICK

*Blowing a bubble in a garden hose -- one weak spot balloons out dangerously. A NEW RISM in the pipe!*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A CT scan incidentally reveals a 5.8 cm infrarenal abdominal aortic aneurysm (AAA). The vascular surgeon recommends elective endovascular repair given the rupture risk.

# Thrombosis

throm-BOH-sis

## DEFINITION

The formation of a blood clot (thrombus) within a blood vessel, obstructing blood flow and potentially causing tissue ischemia or embolization.

## ETYMOLOGY

thrombos (Greek: lump/clot) + -osis (condition)

## MEMORY TRICK

*A DRUM (thromb) jammed into a pipe, blocking all flow downstream.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A post-surgical patient develops unilateral leg swelling. Doppler ultrasound confirms deep vein thrombosis (DVT) in the popliteal vein; anticoagulation with heparin is initiated.

# Stenosis

steh-NOH-sis

## DEFINITION

An abnormal narrowing of a body channel or passage, most commonly referring to blood vessels or heart valves, restricting normal flow.

## ETYMOLOGY

stenos (Greek: narrow) + -osis (condition)

## MEMORY TRICK

*STENO the stenographer worked in a NARROW cubicle -- everything about steno means tight and cramped.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

Echocardiography reveals severe aortic stenosis with a valve area of 0.7 cm<sup>2</sup> and mean gradient of 48 mmHg. The patient is referred for TAVR.

# Ischemia

ih-SKEE-mee-uh

## DEFINITION

Insufficient blood supply to a tissue or organ, resulting in oxygen deprivation and potential cellular damage or death.

## ETYMOLOGY

ischein (Greek: to hold back) + haima (Greek: blood)

## MEMORY TRICK

*IS-HE-ME-A vampire? Something is HOLDING BACK the BLOOD from reaching where it needs to go!*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient presents with crushing substernal chest pain. Troponin levels are elevated and ECG shows ST-depression, consistent with myocardial ischemia requiring urgent catheterization.

# Cardiomyopathy

KAR-dee-oh-my-OP-un-thee

## DEFINITION

A group of diseases affecting the heart muscle itself, impairing its ability to pump blood effectively and potentially leading to heart failure.

## ETYMOLOGY

cardio- (heart) + myo- (muscle) + -pathy (disease/suffering)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The HEART (cardio) MUSCLE (myo) is SICK (pathy) -- like a bodybuilder whose muscles have gone weak and flabby.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 35-year-old with progressive dyspnea is diagnosed with dilated cardiomyopathy on echo, showing EF of 20%. Heart failure management with ACE inhibitors and beta-blockers begins.

# Endocarditis

EN-doh-kar-DY-tis

## DEFINITION

Infection or inflammation of the inner lining of the heart chambers and valves (endocardium), most commonly caused by bacteria colonizing damaged valves.

## ETYMOLOGY

endo- (Greek: within) + kardia (heart) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*Bacteria sneak INSIDE (endo) the HEART (cardia) and throw an inflammatory party (-itis) on the valves.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

An IV drug user presents with fever, new heart murmur, and Janeway lesions. Blood cultures grow Staph aureus, confirming infective endocarditis of the tricuspid valve.

## DAY 2

# Respiratory System

The Lungs & Airways

The respiratory system governs gas exchange and ventilation. These terms cover the most common pulmonary conditions you'll encounter in clinical rotations and board exams.

TERM 11 OF 50

## Pneumothorax

NOO-moh-THOR-aks

### DEFINITION

A condition in which air leaks into the pleural space between the lung and chest wall, causing partial or complete lung collapse.

### ETYMOLOGY

pneumo- (Greek: air/lung) + thorax (Greek: chest)

### MEMORY TRICK

*A PNEUMATIC drill (pneumo) blasts through your CHEST (thorax) wall, letting air leak where it shouldn't be.*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A tall, thin 22-year-old male presents with sudden pleuritic chest pain and dyspnea. Chest X-ray reveals a right-sided spontaneous pneumothorax requiring chest tube insertion.

TERM 12 OF 50

## Bronchitis

brong-KY-tis

### DEFINITION

Inflammation of the bronchial tubes (bronchi), causing cough, mucus production, and airflow obstruction. Can be acute (viral) or chronic (part of COPD).

### ETYMOLOGY

bronch- (Greek: windpipe) + -itis (inflammation)

### MEMORY TRICK

*Your BRONCHIAL tubes are throwing a tantrum (-itis) -- red, swollen, and coughing like an angry bronco!*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A patient presents with a productive cough lasting two weeks after an upper respiratory infection. Treatment is supportive with fluids, rest, and bronchodilators for wheezing.

# Emphysema

em-fih-SEE-muh

## DEFINITION

A chronic lung condition in which the alveoli (air sacs) are damaged and enlarged, reducing gas exchange surface area and causing progressive breathlessness.

## ETYMOLOGY

emphysan (Greek: to inflate, from en- 'in' + physan 'to blow')

## MEMORY TRICK

*Alveoli are OVER-INFLATED like balloons blown too many times -- they stretch out, lose elasticity, and can't deflate.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 68-year-old with a 40-pack-year smoking history shows hyperinflated lungs on CXR. PFTs confirm severe obstruction with reduced DLCO consistent with emphysema.

# Dyspnea

disp-NEE-un

## DEFINITION

The subjective sensation of difficulty breathing or breathlessness, which may indicate pulmonary, cardiac, or other systemic disorders.

## ETYMOLOGY

dys- (Greek: difficult/bad) + pneo (Greek: breathing)

## MEMORY TRICK

*DIS breathing is NOT easy (dys-pnea) -- you're gasping like you just ran a marathon underwater.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient with CHF reports worsening dyspnea on exertion, now occurring climbing half a flight of stairs, classified as NYHA Class III.

# Hemoptysis

hīn-MŌP-th-sīs

## DEFINITION

The coughing up of blood or blood-stained sputum from the lower respiratory tract, requiring urgent evaluation for serious underlying causes.

## ETYMOLOGY

hemo- (Greek: blood) + ptysis (Greek: spitting)

## MEMORY TRICK

*HEMO the vampire tried to SPIT (ptysis) but ended up coughing BLOOD from his lungs!*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 55-year-old smoker presents with two episodes of hemoptysis. CT chest reveals a 3 cm spiculated mass in the right upper lobe, concerning for malignancy.

# Atelectasis

AT-uh-LEK-tuh-sīs

## DEFINITION

Partial or complete collapse of a lung or lung section, occurring when alveoli deflate or fill with fluid. Commonly seen post-operatively.

## ETYMOLOGY

ateles (Greek: incomplete) + ektasis (Greek: expansion)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The lung had an INCOMPLETE (ateles) EXPANSION (ektasis) -- like a parachute that only half-opened.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A post-op patient develops low-grade fever and decreased breath sounds at the left base. CXR confirms left lower lobe atelectasis; incentive spirometry is ordered.

## Pleurisy

*PLUOR-in-see*

### DEFINITION

Inflammation of the pleura (membranes surrounding the lungs), causing sharp chest pain that worsens with breathing or coughing.

### ETYMOLOGY

pleura (Greek: rib/side) + -isy (variant of -itis, inflammation)

### MEMORY TRICK

*Every breath PLEURS (hurts) -- it's like your lungs are wrapped in sandpaper rubbing with each breath.*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A patient with recent viral illness presents with sharp, stabbing chest pain worsening with deep inspiration. A friction rub is heard on auscultation, consistent with pleurisy.

## Cyanosis

*SY-uh-NOH-sis*

### DEFINITION

A bluish discoloration of the skin and mucous membranes from inadequate blood oxygenation, indicating significant hypoxemia.

### ETYMOLOGY

kyanos (Greek: blue) + -osis (condition)

### MEMORY TRICK

*CYAN is a shade of BLUE -- when you see cyanosis, the patient is literally turning blue from low oxygen!*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A newborn presents with central cyanosis unresponsive to supplemental O2. Echo reveals transposition of the great arteries requiring emergent prostaglandin infusion.

# Pulmonary Embolism

PUL-muh-ner-ee EM-buh-liz-um

## DEFINITION

Blockage of a pulmonary artery by a blood clot (usually from DVT), fat, or air, which can be life-threatening by impeding gas exchange.

## ETYMOLOGY

pulmo (Latin: lung) + embolus (Greek: plug/stopper)

## MEMORY TRICK

*A rogue PLUG (embolus) breaks free and travels to the LUNG (pulmonary), jamming the artery like a cork in a bottle.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A post-surgical patient develops sudden dyspnea, tachycardia, and pleuritic chest pain. CTPA confirms bilateral pulmonary emboli; systemic heparin is emergently started.

# Asthma

AZ-muh

## DEFINITION

A chronic inflammatory airway disease with reversible bronchoconstriction, airway hyperresponsiveness, and mucus overproduction, causing recurrent wheezing episodes.

## ETYMOLOGY

asthma (Greek: panting/gasping)

## MEMORY TRICK

*AZ-muh sounds like 'has-muh' -- HAS MY breath gone?! You're gasping and wheezing trying to find it.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 10-year-old presents to the ER with severe wheezing and accessory muscle use after cat exposure. Peak flow is 40% predicted; continuous nebulized albuterol and IV steroids are given.

## DAY 3

# Digestive System

The GI Tract & Accessory Organs

The digestive system processes nutrients across a 30-foot tract. These terms span hepatobiliary, pancreatic, and intestinal pathology essential for clinical practice.

TERM 21 OF 50

## Dysphagia

dis-FAY-jee-un

### DEFINITION

Difficulty swallowing food or liquids, which may result from structural obstruction or motility disorders of the esophagus or oropharynx.

### ETYMOLOGY

dys- (Greek: difficult) + phagein (Greek: to eat/swallow)

### MEMORY TRICK

*DIS-PHAGE-ia: it's DIFFICULT to make food go down the PASSAGE -- food gets stuck on the way down.*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A 70-year-old reports progressive dysphagia to solids over 3 months with 10 lb weight loss. Barium swallow reveals an esophageal stricture; EGD with biopsy is ordered.

TERM 22 OF 50

## Hepatomegaly

HEP-un-ton-MEG-un-lee

### DEFINITION

Abnormal enlargement of the liver, detectable on physical exam or imaging, which may indicate hepatitis, cirrhosis, malignancy, or heart failure.

### ETYMOLOGY

hepato- (Greek: liver) + -megaly (Greek: enlargement)

### MEMORY TRICK

*The LIVER (hepato) has gone MEGA (megaly) -- like the Hulk version of a liver, swollen and oversized.*

### CLINICAL USAGE

On abdominal exam, the liver edge is palpable 4 cm below the right costal margin. US confirms hepatomegaly with 18 cm span; LFTs and hepatitis panel are ordered.

# Cholecystitis

KOL-in-sis-ty-tis

## DEFINITION

Inflammation of the gallbladder, usually caused by gallstones blocking the cystic duct, leading to RUQ pain, fever, and nausea.

## ETYMOLOGY

chole- (Greek: bile) + cyst- (Greek: bladder/sac) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The BILE (chole) BLADDER (cyst) is INFLAMED (-itis) -- a tiny angry balloon full of bile, red and swollen!*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 45-year-old female presents with acute RUQ pain after a fatty meal, positive Murphy's sign, and fever. US shows gallstones with wall thickening; lap chole is planned.

# Peritonitis

PER-in-toh-NY-tis

## DEFINITION

Inflammation of the peritoneum (the membrane lining the abdominal cavity), usually from infection due to perforation, requiring emergency treatment.

## ETYMOLOGY

peritonaion (Greek: stretched around) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The membrane STRETCHED AROUND (peritoneum) your guts is on FIRE (-itis) -- your entire abdominal lining is burning.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient with perforated duodenal ulcer presents with rigid abdomen, rebound tenderness, and guarding. Free air is seen on upright X-ray; emergent surgical exploration follows.

# Cirrhosis

sih-ROH-sis

## DEFINITION

Chronic, irreversible scarring (fibrosis) of the liver from sustained damage, leading to impaired liver function, portal hypertension, and eventual liver failure.

## ETYMOLOGY

kirrhos (Greek: tawny/yellowish-orange) + -osis (condition)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The liver turns TAWNY-ORANGE (kirrhos) like autumn leaves -- it's scarred, stiff, and dying like dried-up foliage.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient with long-standing alcohol use presents with ascites, jaundice, and spider angiomas. Labs show elevated INR and low albumin consistent with decompensated cirrhosis.

# Gastroesophageal Reflux

GAS-tron-ee-SOF-uh-JEE-ul-REE-fluks

## DEFINITION

The backward flow of stomach acid into the esophagus, causing heartburn, regurgitation, and potential esophageal damage when chronic (GERD).

## ETYMOLOGY

gastro- (Greek: stomach) + esophagus (Greek: gullet) + reflux (Latin: flowing back)

## MEMORY TRICK

*STOMACH (gastro) acid FLOWS BACK (reflux) up the GULLET (esophagus) like lava flowing uphill from a volcano.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient with nightly heartburn and acid regurgitation fails lifestyle modifications. Omeprazole 40 mg daily is initiated, with upper endoscopy planned if symptoms persist.

# Pancreatitis

PAN-kree-uh-IY-tis

## DEFINITION

Inflammation of the pancreas, most commonly caused by gallstones or alcohol, presenting with severe epigastric pain radiating to the back.

## ETYMOLOGY

pancreas (Greek: pan- 'all' + kreas 'flesh') + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The organ of ALL FLESH (pan-kreas) is on fire -- imagine a steak burning in your upper abdomen, scorching through to your back.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient presents with acute epigastric pain radiating to the back after binge drinking. Lipase is 5x normal; NPO status, IV fluids, and pain management are initiated.

# Diverticulitis

DY-ver-tik-yoo-LY-tis

## DEFINITION

Inflammation or infection of small pouches (diverticula) that form in the colon walls, causing LLQ pain, fever, and altered bowel habits.

## ETYMOLOGY

diverticulum (Latin: a bypath/side road) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*Little SIDE POCKETS (diverticula) in your colon take a DETOUR (divert) and get INFECTED -- like potholes filling with debris.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 60-year-old presents with LLQ pain, low-grade fever, and leukocytosis. CT reveals sigmoid diverticulitis without abscess; oral antibiotics and clear liquid diet are prescribed.

# Hematemesis

HEE-muh-TEM-ih-sis

## DEFINITION

Vomiting of blood, which may appear bright red or dark coffee-ground-like, indicating bleeding from the upper GI tract.

## ETYMOLOGY

hemo- (Greek: blood) + emesis (Greek: vomiting)

## MEMORY TRICK

*HEMA-TEMESIS: BLOOD (hema) + VOMITING (emesis) = vomiting blood. The TEM sounds like THEM -- THEM bloody vomits!*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient on chronic NSAID therapy presents with hematemesis and melena. Emergent EGD reveals a bleeding gastric ulcer treated with epinephrine injection and thermal coagulation.

# Colonoscopy

KOL-un-NOS-kuh-pee

## DEFINITION

A diagnostic procedure using a flexible, lighted scope to examine the entire colon and rectum for screening, diagnosis, and treatment of colorectal conditions.

## ETYMOLOGY

colon (Greek: large intestine) + -scopy (Greek: to view/examine)

## MEMORY TRICK

*A SCOPE goes on a COLON road trip -- a sightseeing tour through your large intestine looking for trouble.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 50-year-old undergoes routine screening colonoscopy. Two sessile polyps in the ascending colon are removed; histology shows tubular adenomas requiring surveillance in 3 years.

## DAY 4

# Nervous System

The Brain, Spine & Nerves

The nervous system is the body's command center. From peripheral neuropathies to central lesions, these terms are critical for neurological assessment and diagnosis.

TERM 31 OF 50

## Neuropathy

nyoo-ROP-uh-thee

### DEFINITION

Damage or dysfunction of one or more peripheral nerves, causing numbness, tingling, weakness, or pain, most commonly in the hands and feet.

### ETYMOLOGY

neuro- (Greek: nerve) + -pathy (Greek: disease/suffering)

### MEMORY TRICK

*Your NERVES (neuro) are SICK (pathy) -- imagine the electrical wires in your body fraying and short-circuiting.*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A diabetic patient reports burning pain and numbness in both feet in a stocking pattern. NCS confirms peripheral neuropathy; gabapentin is prescribed alongside tighter glycemic control.

TERM 32 OF 50

## Encephalitis

en-SEF-un-LY-tis

### DEFINITION

Inflammation of the brain parenchyma, most commonly caused by viral infection, presenting with fever, headache, altered mental status, and possible seizures.

### ETYMOLOGY

encephalo- (Greek: brain, literally 'within the head') + -itis (inflammation)

### MEMORY TRICK

*What's IN YOUR HEAD (encephalo) is on FIRE (-itis) -- your brain is inflamed and swelling inside your skull.*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A patient presents with fever, confusion, and temporal lobe seizures. CSF and MRI suggest herpes simplex encephalitis; IV acyclovir is initiated emergently.

# Meningitis

MEN-in-JY-us

## DEFINITION

Inflammation of the meninges (protective membranes around the brain and spinal cord), presenting with headache, neck stiffness, fever, and photophobia.

## ETYMOLOGY

meninx (Greek: membrane) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The MEMBRANE (meninx) wrapping your brain is INFLAMED -- shrink-wrap around your brain getting hot, tight, and painful.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A college student presents with severe headache, neck stiffness, and petechial rash. LP shows neutrophilic pleocytosis; empiric ceftriaxone and dexamethasone are started.

# Hemiplegia

HEM-ee-PLLEE-jee-uh

## DEFINITION

Complete paralysis affecting one side of the body (left or right), typically from stroke, traumatic brain injury, or other CNS lesions.

## ETYMOLOGY

hemi- (Greek: half) + plege (Greek: stroke/blow)

## MEMORY TRICK

*HALF (hemi) your body got HIT (plege) and can't move -- like someone drew a line down the middle and turned off one side.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient post-MCA stroke presents with right-sided hemiplegia and aphasia. Rehabilitation with PT, OT, and speech-language pathology is initiated.

# Epilepsy

EP-in-lep-see

## DEFINITION

A chronic neurological disorder characterized by recurrent, unprovoked seizures due to abnormal excessive electrical activity in the brain.

## ETYMOLOGY

epilepsia (Greek: seizure, from epilambanein 'to seize upon')

## MEMORY TRICK

*Electrical storms SEIZE (epilambanein) the brain -- a power surge that causes the circuits to misfire repeatedly.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient with two unprovoked generalized tonic-clonic seizures 6 months apart undergoes EEG showing epileptiform discharges. Levetiracetam is initiated and driving restrictions discussed.

# Neuralgia

nyoo-RAL-jee-un

## DEFINITION

Intense, often stabbing pain along a nerve's distribution, caused by irritation or damage without an obvious structural lesion.

## ETYMOLOGY

neuro- (Greek: nerve) + -algia (Greek: pain)

## MEMORY TRICK

*Your NERVE (neuro) is screaming in AGONY (algia) -- it sends lightning bolts of pain along its entire pathway.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient describes excruciating, electric-shock-like facial pain triggered by chewing. MRI is normal; carbamazepine is started for trigeminal neuralgia.

# Cerebrovascular Accident

SER-ih-broh-VAS-kyoo-ler AK-sin-dent

## DEFINITION

Commonly known as a stroke: the sudden interruption of blood supply to the brain via vessel blockage (ischemic) or rupture (hemorrhagic), causing neurological deficits.

## ETYMOLOGY

cerebro- (Latin: brain) + vascular (Latin: small vessel) + accident (Latin: to happen)

## MEMORY TRICK

*A car ACCIDENT happens in the BRAIN's (cerebro) BLOOD VESSELS (vascular) -- sudden, unexpected, and causing major damage.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient presents with acute left-sided weakness and slurred speech, onset 90 minutes ago. CT rules out hemorrhage; IV alteplase is administered within the treatment window.

# Hydrocephalus

HY-droh-SEF-un-lus

## DEFINITION

Abnormal accumulation of cerebrospinal fluid within the brain's ventricles, causing increased intracranial pressure and potential brain damage.

## ETYMOLOGY

hydro- (Greek: water) + cephalus (Greek: head)

## MEMORY TRICK

*WATER (hydro) is flooding the HEAD (cephalus) -- the brain's ventricles filling up like a bathtub with a clogged drain.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

An infant presents with rapidly enlarging head circumference and bulging fontanelle. CT shows dilated ventricles; a ventriculoperitoneal shunt is placed.

# Paresthesia

PAR-es-THEE-zee-uh

## DEFINITION

Abnormal skin sensations such as tingling, prickling, or numbness ('pins and needles') without apparent cause, often indicating nerve dysfunction.

## ETYMOLOGY

para- (Greek: beside/abnormal) + aisthesis (Greek: sensation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*Your SENSATION (aisthesis) has gone SIDEWAYS (para) -- that 'pins and needles' feeling when your foot falls asleep.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient with carpal tunnel reports tingling in the thumb, index, and middle fingers. NCS confirms median nerve compression at the wrist.

# Sclerosis

sklee-ROH-sis

## DEFINITION

Abnormal hardening or thickening of body tissue, commonly referring to nerve myelin sheaths (multiple sclerosis) or arterial walls.

## ETYMOLOGY

skleros (Greek: hard) + -osis (condition)

## MEMORY TRICK

*Tissue gets HARD (skleros) as CONCRETE -- in MS, the soft myelin insulation around nerves turns into stiff scar tissue.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 28-year-old female presents with optic neuritis and limb paresthesias separated in time and space. MRI shows periventricular white matter lesions consistent with MS.

## DAY 5

# Musculoskeletal System

Bones, Joints & Muscles

The musculoskeletal system provides structure, movement, and protection. These terms cover bone, joint, and muscle pathologies across orthopedic and rheumatologic practice.

TERM 41 OF 50

## Osteoporosis

OS-tee-on-puh-ROH-sis

### DEFINITION

A systemic skeletal disease with decreased bone density and deterioration of bone microarchitecture, leading to fragility and increased fracture risk.

### ETYMOLOGY

osteo- (Greek: bone) + poros (Greek: passage/pore) + -osis (condition)

### MEMORY TRICK

*BONES (osteo) become POROUS (poros) like Swiss cheese -- full of holes that make them fragile and easy to break.*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A 65-year-old postmenopausal woman sustains a vertebral compression fracture from bending. DEXA shows T-score of -3.2; alendronate, calcium, and vitamin D are prescribed.

TERM 42 OF 50

## Arthritis

ar-THRY-tis

### DEFINITION

Inflammation of one or more joints, causing pain, swelling, and stiffness. Major types include osteoarthritis (degenerative) and rheumatoid arthritis (autoimmune).

### ETYMOLOGY

arthro- (Greek: joint) + -itis (inflammation)

### MEMORY TRICK

*Your JOINTS (arthro) are throwing an inflammatory party (-itis) -- red, swollen, hot, and nobody was invited!*

### CLINICAL USAGE

A patient presents with symmetric MCP and PIP joint swelling with morning stiffness >1 hour. RF and anti-CCP are positive; methotrexate is initiated for RA.

# Scoliosis

SKOL-ee-OH-sis

## DEFINITION

An abnormal lateral curvature of the spine, most commonly diagnosed in adolescence, ranging from mild (monitored) to severe (requiring bracing or surgery).

## ETYMOLOGY

skolios (Greek: crooked/curved) + -osis (condition)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The spine goes CROOKED (skolios) like the letter S instead of standing straight like the letter I.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A 13-year-old girl's screening reveals asymmetric shoulders. Standing X-ray shows a 32-degree thoracic curve; a TLSO brace is prescribed for 18 hours daily.

# Tendinitis

TEN-din-NY-tis

## DEFINITION

Inflammation or irritation of a tendon (the cord attaching muscle to bone), usually caused by repetitive motion or overuse injuries.

## ETYMOLOGY

tendon (Latin: to stretch) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The STRETCHED cord (tendon) connecting muscle to bone is INFLAMED -- an overstretched rubber band that's now red and angry.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A tennis player presents with lateral elbow pain worsening with gripping. Tenderness over the lateral epicondyle confirms lateral epicondylitis; PT and a brace are recommended.

# Myalgia

my-AL-jee-un

## DEFINITION

Muscle pain, localized or diffuse, commonly associated with overexertion, infections, or systemic conditions like autoimmune disease.

## ETYMOLOGY

myo- (Greek: muscle) + -algia (Greek: pain)

## MEMORY TRICK

*MY (myo) muscles are in AGONY (algia) -- MY-ALGIA literally translates to 'my muscle pain!'*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient started on atorvastatin 2 months ago reports diffuse myalgias and tenderness. CK is mildly elevated; the statin is switched to a lower-intensity alternative.

# Fracture

FRAK-chur

## DEFINITION

A partial or complete break in bone continuity, resulting from trauma, stress, or pathological weakness, classified by pattern, location, and severity.

## ETYMOLOGY

fractura (Latin: a break, from frangere 'to break')

## MEMORY TRICK

*CRACK-ture! You hear the CRACK when a bone FRACTURES -- the word even sounds like breaking.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient falls on an outstretched hand with wrist deformity. X-ray reveals a dorsally angulated distal radius fracture (Colles); closed reduction and casting are performed.

# Lordosis

lor-DOH-sis

## DEFINITION

An exaggerated inward curvature of the lumbar spine (swayback), which can be postural, congenital, or secondary to obesity or pregnancy.

## ETYMOLOGY

lordos (Greek: bent backward) + -osis (condition)

## MEMORY TRICK

*A LORD bowing backward dramatically -- that exaggerated backward curve in the lower back is lordosis.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A pregnant patient in her third trimester reports increasing low back pain. Exam reveals exaggerated lumbar lordosis; prenatal exercises and a support belt are recommended.

# Bursitis

bur-SY-tis

## DEFINITION

Inflammation of a bursa, a small fluid-filled sac that cushions bones, tendons, and muscles near joints, commonly affecting shoulder, elbow, or hip.

## ETYMOLOGY

bursa (Latin: purse/sac) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*The tiny PURSE (bursa) of fluid at your joint gets INFLAMED -- a water balloon at your joint getting red, hot, and swollen.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A patient who frequently kneels for work presents with anterior knee swelling. Exam reveals prepatellar bursitis; treatment includes rest, NSAIDs, and avoiding prolonged kneeling.

# Osteomyelitis

OS-tee-on-MY-un-LY-tis

## DEFINITION

Infection of the bone, usually bacterial, reaching via bloodstream, direct injury, or adjacent tissue spread, requiring prolonged antibiotic therapy.

## ETYMOLOGY

osteo- (Greek: bone) + myelo- (Greek: marrow) + -itis (inflammation)

## MEMORY TRICK

*Bacteria invade the BONE (osteo) into the MARROW (myelo) causing INFLAMMATION (-itis) -- infection deep in the bone's core.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

A diabetic with a non-healing foot ulcer develops fever and deep bone pain. MRI shows marrow edema and cortical destruction; IV antibiotics are started for 6 weeks.

# Kyphosis

ky-FOH-sis

## DEFINITION

An exaggerated forward rounding of the upper back (thoracic spine), giving a hunched posture, often seen in elderly patients with osteoporosis.

## ETYMOLOGY

kyphos (Greek: bent/humpback) + -osis (condition)

## MEMORY TRICK

*A HUNCHBACK (kyphos) -- the upper back curves forward into a C shape, like you're perpetually curling over a phone.*

## CLINICAL USAGE

An 80-year-old woman presents with progressive thoracic kyphosis and height loss. X-ray reveals multiple vertebral compression fractures; pain management and osteoporosis treatment are intensified.

# Congratulations!

You've completed the VividMed 5 Day Challenge.

---

You now have a solid foundation in 50 essential medical terms spanning cardiovascular, respiratory, digestive, nervous, and musculoskeletal systems. Review these terms regularly, quiz yourself on the etymologies and mnemonics, and apply them in your clinical studies and rotations.

**VIVIDMED**

*Making Medical Education Memorable*